POWERTOFLY AI

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Who makes AI *work?*

A practical guide to the people behind AI that delivers



With advice from 12 HR, talent and AI leaders at the PowerToFly AI Summit, October 14, 2026

INTRODUCTION

Why AI needs the right people around it

Picture the last AI tool your company rolled out. You bought the licenses, ran a kickoff everyone was excited about and watched the demo win over the room. Six months later, a handful of people use it regularly, nobody's quite sure who owns it, and you're still waiting on the results everyone hoped for.

If that sounds familiar, you're in good company.

80%+

of AI projects don't deliver the business value they were meant to

RAND

95%

of generative AI pilots never make it past proof of concept

MIT

70%

of AI challenges come from people and processes, with only 10% coming from the AI itself

BCG

That's good news, because it means the fix is probably closer to home than another new tool.

This guide takes each of the five people gaps we see in turn, with the steps we recommend and a short exercise to try with your team. It draws on PowerToFly AI's research and on advice from 12 HR, talent and AI leaders who joined us for the PowerToFly AI Summit in October 2026.



12 HR, talent and AI leaders from the PowerToFly AI Summit

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

Five people gaps decide whether AI pays off

When we talk to clients about this, we describe five gaps. Each section that follows covers one of them, with what to do about it.

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Nobody defined the problem or the payoff before buying.

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Nobody owns AI.

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Nobody with the right expertise checks the work.

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GAP 01

Define the problem and the payoff before you buy

Before you buy an AI tool or start a pilot, write down the problem it solves, what success looks like and how you'll measure it. Skipping this step is the most common mistake we see.

It's an easy one to make. For two years, leaders have been told that if they weren't using AI yesterday, they're already behind, so plenty of companies bought first and planned later. Many of them now have a tool everyone can log into and very little to show for it.

> **"The biggest thing is buying tools before we know what problem we're trying to solve."**
>
> 
> **Elena Agaragimova**
> Head of People, Horizon Industries

How to set up an AI project to pay off

01 **Start from the workflow.** Ask how you'd design the process from scratch now that AI is available. The biggest gains come from rethinking a whole workflow, well beyond writing one email a little faster.

02 **Decide what the payoff is.** Time saved only matters once you know where that time goes. Tie each use to one of three outcomes: more revenue, lower costs or less risk.

03 **Count the time spent checking.** If AI doubles your team's output but someone now spends two hours reviewing it, you've gained capability without gaining value.

04 **Check who has the hours.** Knowing you can build something with AI is different from knowing if you should. Think about who has time to build it and keep it running.

05 **Estimate the running cost.** Some teams are finding that usage fees for an AI workflow add up to more than paying a person to do the same work.

> **“A pilot’s never gonna work if you don’t know what success looks like and how you’re gonna measure that at the end of it.”**



Eryn Peters
Co-founder, AI Maturity Index

TRY THIS WITH YOUR TEAM

Before your next pilot starts, fill in a one-page brief. Use the one below as your starting point: if a line stays blank, that’s where to begin.

ONE-PAGE BRIEF · FILL IN BEFORE THE PILOT STARTS

The problem, in one sentence _____

Who has it today _____

What success looks like _____

How we’ll measure it _____ **Check date** _____

Outcome it moves ☐ Revenue ☐ Cost ☐ Risk

What we’ll do with time saved _____

Running cost (usage + review time) _____

Who builds and maintains it _____

GAP 02

Make one person accountable for AI

Name one person who's accountable for how your company uses AI, give them the authority to work across every team and give employees an approved tool from day one.

Without an owner, AI decisions get made in silos. Rollouts get stuck at whichever team inherits them, and employees fill the gap with their own tools. Regulators are starting to ask the same question too. Colorado has already passed an AI law that other states are watching, the EU's rules are phasing in over the next couple of years, and when an auditor asks who's responsible for an AI decision, "the team" won't be an acceptable answer.

> **"Say your AI decides to curse out a client. Who's responsible for that? You're gonna say, what, Claude did it? No. We have to have somebody who's actually responsible."**



Mara Gates
Director of Content Marketing, PowerToFly AI

What the owner needs

01 **Reach across the company.** AI touches engineering, marketing, talent acquisition, legal and finance. The owner needs the standing to set one approach for all of them.

02 **Change management skills as well as technical ones.** Much of the job is explaining the same plan in terms engineers, marketers and legal teams each care about, and bringing skeptical people along.

03 **HR and talent at the table from the start.** They hear what employees actually think, and they often end up running the rollout. We've seen tools a CEO loved fail at handoff because HR found out about them last.

04 **A plan for smaller teams.** If you don't have an AI team, ownership sits with leadership (often the CEO), who sets the expectations and guardrails, trains people on them and gives everyone access to approved tools.

> **"Everybody owns it, but nobody owns it. Nobody's really accountable."**



Elena Agaragimova
Head of People, Horizon Industries

Give people a safe option, fast

When access to AI is restricted, employees rarely wait. They use personal accounts, paste company data into them and sometimes connect them to work email.

> **"They're probably just using their own. So they're putting sensitive company data into a personal AI tool."**
>
> 
> **Shawntay Skjoldager**
> COO and Integrator, ThinkHuman

We recommend this order of operations

01 **Pick one approved tool and use its enterprise version,** so your data isn't used to train anyone's model. Are you team Claude or team Gemini? Or maybe something else? Whatever the case, this should be a clear, documented decision.

02 **Write the policy, then enforce it.** A written AI policy says what people can and can't do. A data policy, enforced by IT, controls which systems the tool can connect to.

03 **Remind people what's private.** Most employees have signed something saying company systems carry no expectation of privacy, and AI tools work the same way.

04 **Ship something before it's perfect.** A simple internal tool, available quickly, keeps people off personal accounts while your governance catches up. Expect to adjust the rules as you learn what's too strict and what's too loose.

> **"It may not be as good, but at least it's something."**
>
> 
> **Stephen Salaka**
> AI Enablement Manager, HII Mission Technologies
> *On launching an internal AI tool for more than 8,000 people*

TRY THIS WITH YOUR TEAM

Write down, on one page, who owns AI at your company, which tools are approved, what data can go into them and who people should ask when they're unsure.

If you can't fill in the first line, start there.

GAP 03

Put experts in charge of checking the work

Plan for people on both ends of every AI workflow: someone to prepare what goes in and someone who knows the subject well enough to judge what comes out. Then match how closely you review to how much is at stake.

AI can produce a polished, confident answer that's completely wrong. Someone who knows the subject will catch it in minutes, while someone new to it will pass it along. Most AI budgets go to engineers and data teams, and those people are essential. Far less goes to the people in finance, HR, legal or customer service who can tell whether an answer is right.

> **"Data is messy, and humans both need to organize it for the bots, and then they need to check the data that the bots give. We have to work together. It can't be one or the other."**
>
> 
> **Milena Berry**
> Co-founder and CEO, PowerToFly AI

Build review into the product

The people who train and test your AI shape how well it works for everyone who uses it. Bringing in reviewers with different backgrounds and specialties is how you catch problems before your customers do. We focus on three places it pays off:

01

Bias testing before launch

A team with similar backgrounds can build something that offends or fails another group without noticing.

02

Real-world testing

Running your product past people with different profiles shows how it behaves for the full range of people who'll use it.

03

Expert review for expert users

If you're building for lawyers or HR teams, people from those fields should be training and testing it, so it stays inside the guardrails you set.

Hiring tools show what happens without this. If a team has always hired the same profile from the same schools, a screening tool trained on those decisions will repeat them, so you miss strong candidates and take on legal risk at the same time.

> **"In the models world, this is a need-to-have, because your model just won't perform if you don't expose it to the right domain expert."**
>
> 
> **Milena Berry**
> Co-founder and CEO, PowerToFly AI

Match the review to the stakes

No team has the people to review everything, so decide where review matters most. Anything that affects hiring, goes to a client or carries legal or financial weight gets an expert's eyes every time. A tool that suggests the wrong training course is a much smaller problem.

High stakes	Hiring and screening decisions, anything sent to clients or partners, legal or financial content	WHO REVIEWS **A subject expert, every time, before it goes out**
Medium stakes	Internal reports and analysis, team communications	WHO REVIEWS **The owner, plus spot checks**
Low stakes	Personal drafts, meeting notes, brainstorming	WHO REVIEWS **The person using it**

The review has to be thorough, too. AI answers usually look finished, which makes it tempting to accept the first draft without checking it. That's how mistakes get through. We've heard stories of lawyers, for example, who have filed briefs citing court cases that AI made up, with names close enough to real cases that a quick read didn't catch them.

> **"I hit the easy button, it generated for me, and now I gotta go back and put my editor hat on."**
>
> 
>
> **Stephen Salaka**
> AI Enablement Manager, HII Mission Technologies
> *On the need for human review*

Making the case to your CFO

When reviewers and subject experts show up as a cost line, the conversation goes badly. Present them as part of the product, since a model without them won't work as intended. The case is easier when your CFO and your head of people are already talking about AI and talent before any budget request lands, so the numbers on rework, turnover and adoption are part of a picture they've both seen.

TRY THIS WITH YOUR TEAM

List your AI uses, sort them into high, medium and low stakes, and check that every high-stakes use has a named expert reviewing it.

GAP 04

Hire for the work AI needs done

Define the work before you define the candidate. Most companies struggling to hire for AI have done it the other way round, and it shows up in three places: how the role is written, where they look and how they interview.

> **"The mistake is deciding what an AI candidate must look like before it's really clear what job they're actually going to be doing."**
>
> 
>
> **Fran Griffin**
> Talent Acquisition Manager, PowerToFly AI

Write the role around the work

01 **Start with what the person will actually do.** A machine learning engineer needs deep technical skills. A team applying AI to healthcare, or checking how a model responds in other languages, needs clinical knowledge, language expertise and people who can train others.

02 **Cut requirements the work doesn't need.** AI job titles, specific degrees, big-name employers and years of experience with tools that have barely existed all screen out people who could do the job well.

03 **Ask for transferable skills.** Research, clear communication and critical thinking are what let someone use AI well and question it when it's wrong.

04 **Expect basic AI fluency.** For most office roles, it's becoming like knowing Microsoft Office. You may not list it, but you should ask how candidates use AI in their work today.

> **"It is indeed ridiculous when I see people asking for 10 years of RAG pipeline experience."**
>
> 
>
> **Katy Peichert**
> EMEA and LATAM Talent Partner, Front
> *On job descriptions that ask for more years of experience than the technology has existed. RAG, a common way of connecting AI models to a company's own data, has only been in wide use for a few years.*

Look in more places

There's no single right place to find AI talent, so change at least one habit in how you search, whether that's where you post, how you source or how you reach out. Our recruiters see real differences by region:

EUROPE

Asks for responsible-use and governance skills more explicitly, partly because of EU regulation.

NETHERLANDS & IRELAND

High concentrations of AI engineering talent, worth adding to searches that usually stop at the largest markets.

SOUTHEAST ASIA

Growing fast, though specialist profiles in Thailand, Indonesia and Malaysia are still hard to find.

LATIN AMERICA

Earlier in adoption, with Chile standing out as a fast-growing source of AI engineering skills.

> Where specialists are scarce, hire people with strong software or data experience and help them learn the rest.

Some of your best candidates may already work for you

If you need someone productive next month, you may have to hire from outside. If you have a few months, you can build. Depending on what your company already has, there are four ways to find internal candidates:

A skills or competency matrix

If you keep one up to date in a tool like Cornerstone or Fuel50

Talent reviews

Where leaders compare what the business needs with who has related skills

Internal chat channels

Where you can see who's already posting about their AI experiments

Your internal job board

Because the people who apply are telling you they're ready

Interview for judgment

Credentials show that someone prepared for the work. The interview shows how they'll actually do it. Someone who questions an approach and asks for a good reason is often worth more than someone who builds whatever they're asked to.

KEEP THIS CARD · INTERVIEW FOR JUDGMENT

Five questions that show how someone will do the work

01 "Walk me through a project: the problem, why you chose your approach and what happened."

02 "Which parts of that did you build yourself?"

03 "Tell me about an AI result you didn't trust. How did you check it?"

04 "Explain a technical decision the way you would to someone in finance."

05 "How did you get up to speed on a tool you'd never used before?"

Listen for an honest account of what went wrong and what they learned.

> **“The credentials are how you know that someone can do the work. The interview is how you know what they are going to be like while doing the work.”**
>
> 
> **Meg Alexander**
> Virtual Event Host, PowerToFly AI

Make sure strong candidates reach the interview at all. Automated filters often reject people for a missing degree or keyword before anyone looks at their work, including people with AI certifications and shipped projects. Have a person review the skills the role needs before the filters do the deciding.

> **“It’s very important to have a human looking at everything. Don’t rely on your tech tools to screen people out.”**
>
> 
> **Jennyn Herrera**
> Head of Talent Acquisition, Biola University
> *On automated candidate screening*

Be ready for the questions candidates ask you

Strong AI candidates are interviewing you as well. Have clear answers to these:

What will I own?
How established is the team, and will I have the resources to deliver?

Is there real demand and budget behind this role?
Senior candidates who’ve lived through earlier technology waves ask this early.

Is the data ready?
Building an AI product and spending your first months cleaning data are both valuable, but they’re different jobs.

Will I have support to learn?
Earlier-career candidates want experienced colleagues and regular feedback.

Will the offer match what we discussed?
A lower number than the one mentioned early on is one of the fastest ways to lose a strong candidate.

Not sure which part of your process is slowing your search?
Our short quiz shows whether the issue is how your role is written, where you’re looking or how you’re interviewing.

Take the quiz →

TRY THIS WITH YOUR TEAM

Take one open role and question one requirement, whether that’s a job title, a degree, a past employer or a specific tool.

If the work doesn’t truly need it, swap it for the ability you do need, then review five people you’d have screened out before, including at least one from inside your company.

GAP 05

Build habits that last past the launch

Treat AI adoption as ongoing change management. Watch how people behave for early warning signs, make learning hands-on and social, and measure the value AI creates along with how often people use it.

Timing matters here. By the time an engagement survey flags a problem with an AI rollout, things often started going wrong 6 to 18 months earlier. What's holding a company back also varies. Some companies promise job security and still see low usage, while others have employees eager to use AI who are stuck waiting on approvals.

Watch for early warning signs

01

Workarounds

People using personal accounts, hiding how they use AI or building processes on the side usually don't know what they're allowed to do and don't feel safe asking.

02

Mixed messages from managers

One manager says experiment, another says don't touch it and a third says use it but don't make mistakes. Most employees experience change through their direct manager, so that's where the message gets lost.

03

Silence

When nobody asks questions during a training or an all-hands, don't assume everyone's on board. People often stay quiet because they don't trust what they're hearing, or don't think speaking up will change anything.

> **"Our middle management is our translation layer. The way that people actually experience AI, or experience change in general, is usually through their direct managers."**



Kelly Blackmon
Founder, B.E. Consulting

When people hold back, it's usually fear or confusion, and each needs a different answer. For fear, be specific about what AI means for each role and what support is available to learn new skills. For confusion, explain what problem you want AI to solve in their work. Either way, plan for an ongoing conversation instead of a single announcement at a town hall.

> **"What problem do you want me to solve with that tool, so that I know what I'm actually using it for and also not being afraid of it?"**
>
> 
> **Elena Agaragimova**
> Head of People, Horizon Industries

Make learning hands-on and social

01 **Practice on real work.** Courses help, but people learn by using AI on tasks they actually need to get done.

02 **Learn together.** Set up a shared channel or a regular show-and-tell where people post what they've built and what's working.

03 **Name champions on both sides.** Culture champions help people buy into the change, and technical champions help them get started.

04 **Lead by example.** When leaders use AI themselves and protect time for learning, their teams follow.

05 **Make the approved way the easy way.** If your approved tools are easier than the workaround, people will use them.

06 **Address concerns through policy.** Some employees have ethical or environmental concerns about AI. You don't need to change their values, but your policies can address the most common worries.

> **"Nothing beats putting my hands on the keyboard, typing a prompt out, trying to play around with building this agent because I need to get some work done."**
>
> 
> **Aniya Grimm**
> Head of Talent Success, Amplitude

> This pays off in retention too. Employees want autonomy and room to grow, and time and support to build AI skills delivers both.

Measure value along with usage

Logins and usage counts tell you people opened the tool, but they don't tell you whether it helped.

01 **Set a baseline by role.** Before rolling out AI, measure how long key tasks take (for example, hours a week spent on email). Measure again after, and stop using AI for tasks where nothing changed.

02 **Budget usage by outcome.** A flat usage allowance per person ignores what different roles are responsible for.

03 **Set limits where there's no payoff.** Spend without a cap or an outcome attached can grow fast.

04 **Report against outcomes.** Tie results back to the revenue, cost or risk goals you set before the project started.

BUDGET BY OUTCOME

£8,500

One company we heard about let an employee spend about 8,500 British pounds in AI usage in a week without concern, because that person had cut a **90-day process down to eight days**.

CAP WHERE THERE'S NO PAYOFF

$50,000

Another team got a $50,000 bill after a few developers moved all their coding work into the company's AI tool **without any usage caps**.

> **"Everybody got a login, and where are my results?"**
>
> 
>
> **Eryn Peters**
> Co-founder, AI Maturity Index
> *On where most companies are stuck today*

TRY THIS WITH YOUR TEAM

Talk to your middle managers. Ask what they believe the company is trying to do with AI and what their teams think they're allowed to do.

Don't correct them; just listen, and use what you hear to decide what to communicate next.

BEYOND THE FIVE GAPS

Choosing an outside AI partner

Start with a trusted advisor who can help you decide what to build, buy or hire, then choose partners on proof of results over the polish of their pitch.

Most companies need some outside expertise for AI, and it's getting harder to judge. AI makes it easy to produce an impressive proposal, so a polished deck tells you less than it used to. Good partners fail too when the scope is vague and the client expects AI to solve everything. Size isn't the test either. Smaller specialists can tailor their work closely to your needs, and more of them now price by results instead of hours.

> **"If you have a good vendor, that's great. If you have a good vendor and you don't have a good scope of work, not great."**
>
> 
>
> **Ken Sterling**
> AI, tech and media attorney, Sterling Media Law
> *On what goes wrong in AI implementation contracts*

Before you sign with an AI partner

- [ ] Learn enough yourself to know what to ask, or bring in a fractional advisor who does
- [ ] Ask them to walk you through your specific problem live
- [ ] Consider a small paid trial with a defined result before a larger contract
- [ ] Talk to references who hired them for something similar
- [ ] Write a detailed scope of work with clear outcomes
- [ ] Agree on how your team will learn from the work, so you aren't dependent on them for every change

> **"You can't prompt fast enough to talk to me and walk me through and show me confidently that you know what you're doing."**
>
> 
>
> **Kelly Blackmon**
> Founder, B.E. Consulting

CHECKLIST

Your first 30 days

You don’t need to fix all five gaps at once. Pick the ones that sound most like your company and start here.

01 Define the problem and the payoff

- [ ] Fill in a one-page brief for your next AI pilot before it starts
- [ ] List your current AI initiatives, close the ones that aren’t working and double down on the ones that are

02 Make one person accountable

- [ ] Name the person who owns AI at your company, or decide who it should be
- [ ] Pick one approved tool and publish a short, good-enough policy now instead of waiting for a perfect one

03 Put experts in charge of checking the work

- [ ] Sort your AI uses by stakes and name an expert reviewer for every high-stakes one
- [ ] Look at who builds and tests your AI, and widen that group where it’s narrow

04 Hire for the work

- [ ] Question one requirement on an open role, then review five people you’d have screened out before
- [ ] Make sure a person reviews candidates’ skills before automated filters reject them
- [ ] Look through your internal channels for people already posting about AI, and ask what they’re working on

05 Build habits that last

- [ ] Use AI more yourself, and share real examples with your team
- [ ] Start a regular show-and-tell where people share what they’re doing with AI
- [ ] Ask your middle managers what they think the company is doing with AI, and listen without correcting

CONTRIBUTORS

The people behind this guide

This guide draws on advice from the speakers at the PowerToFly AI Summit on October 14, 2026.



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Moderated by Meg Alexander and Rob Ribar of PowerToFly AI and Hunter Lee Canning, co-founder of Plumwheel.

HOW WE HELP

Where PowerToFly AI can help

Every gap in this guide comes back to the same through line: you need people who know the work well enough to make AI useful and catch it when it's wrong.

PowerToFly AI helps companies hire those people and train your models, drawing on a community of 1.1M members.

1.1M
community members

380K+
verified experts

65K+
AI specialists

Watch the full conversations

This guide covers what to do. For the stories behind it, from a 140-year-old shipbuilder rolling out AI to more than 8,000 people to recruiters comparing notes on the interview questions that show judgment, watch the three conversations from the PowerToFly AI Summit.

WATCH THE RECORDING

From Data to Deployment: Why the Humans Behind Your Model Determine Its ROI

WATCH THE RECORDING

The Hiring Gap: Why Most Companies Are Looking for AI Talent in All the Wrong Places

WATCH THE RECORDING

Beyond the Pilot: How to Lead an AI Transformation That Sticks

IF HIRING IS WHERE YOU'RE STUCK

Why aren't the right AI candidates finding you?

Take the quiz →